

RESEARCH AGENDA FOR THE NATIONAL HIV RESPONSE

SUMMARY

The research agenda was developed by the M&E TWG of the national HIV/STI/TB programme. The process was conducted using a modified Essential National Health Research (ENHR) strategy. The preparatory work was completed by the Chair and Co-Chair of the M&E TWG in developing the strategy and preparing the preliminary list. Stakeholder consultation was used to finalize the complete list of the research areas to be considered in the prioritization exercise. The criteria for developing the ranked list included appropriateness, relevancy, the chance of success and the impact of the research outcome for each research area. The prioritization process was completed over a 2-week period and the results were discussed at a consensus meeting with the stakeholders. A total of 11 research areas were assessed and 10 achieved a priority score. There are 3 high priority research areas and 7 priority research areas for the HIV programme. These research areas include:

High Priority

1. HIV prevention measures
2. Ageing in PLHIV
3. STI incidence, prevalence, and epidemiology

Priority

4. Reproductive health in persons living with HIV
5. Barriers/Facilitators to universal access to care for PLHIV
6. The impact of violence, trauma and adverse childhood events on health of PLHIV and key and vulnerable populations
7. Sustainability of the HIV/STI/TB programme
8. HIV drug resistance
9. Co-infections and communicable diseases in PLHIV
10. Health Information Systems and data use for programme management

The research agenda is to be reviewed every 2-3 years to ensure the priorities are still relevant to the national programme and agreed upon by all stakeholders.

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INTRODUCTION

At the end of 2022, there is an estimated 30,000 persons living with HIV in Jamaica of which only 44% are on treatment and 34% are virally suppressed. To improve these indicators the National Strategic Plan for HIV 2023-2030 outlines various strategies in governance, prevention, treatment, enabling environments and human rights and strategic information. In addition to the NSP an M&E plan to measure the effectiveness of the NSP was developed and the research agenda forms a part of that M&E Plan.

A research agenda provides strategic directions on how resources and efforts can be focused to ensure alignment with national research priorities. Therefore, the development of a research agenda will require a credible and transparent process to ensure buy-in from all stakeholders. It is in this light that the Essential National Health Research (ENHR) Strategy was used to guide the process to be used in developing this research agenda.

The Context

The following context was used in the development of the complete list of research areas to be considered for the prioritization process.

Burden of disease. The estimated prevalence of HIV in Jamaica is 1.3%, with higher prevalence for high-risk groups including MSM (30%) TG (50%) FSW (2%). There is an alarming trend of increasing proportion of new HIV diagnoses in persons aged 15-24 years old. Of the estimated number of PLHIV in Jamaica, 44% are retained on ARV and 34% are virally suppressed.

Populations of interest. MSM, FSW, TG, adolescents/youth aged 15-24, sexually active males and females.

Existing policies/targets. Epidemic control (incidence/prevalence ratio = less than or equal to 0.03), Of the total estimated population of PLHIV 95% diagnosed, 90% on ART and 86% virally suppressed (95 – 95 – 95)

Level of Urgency. Very limited capacity for research and limited research output to guide programmatic decisions makes this research agenda very urgent.

Time Frame. 5-year agenda

Aims and Objectives

Aim: Setting research priorities to achieve epidemic control of HIV
(incidence/prevalence ratio = less than or equal to 0.03)

Objectives:

1. To develop a 5-year research agenda for the national HIV programme to align with the M&E plan of the 2023-2030 National Strategic Plan for HIV
2. To develop a report of the research priority-setting process and outcomes to facilitate repeatability.

METHODS

This process was based on The Essential National Health Research (ENHR) strategy for setting priorities in health research and was guided by the M&E technical working group of M&E experts in the national HIV response. The core principles of the process are putting/local country concerns first, working towards equity and linking research to action. The ENHR strategy is characterized by:

- Inclusiveness
- Involvement of a broad range of stakeholders
- Multidisciplinary and cross-sectoral approach
- Partnership development
- Participatory and transparent process
- Systematic analyses of health needs, societal and professional expectations.

The main steps included:

Development of a list of research areas of interest: The M&E technical working group convened a meeting to discuss the research areas of interest to the national HIV response with all stakeholders (*Appendix 1*). To orient all participants a situational analysis of the national HIV programme was presented. Stakeholders were then led through a discussion on the listed research areas for feedback.

Consolidation: Selected research areas of interest were cleaned and consolidated following feedback from the M&E TWG. Following the stakeholder consultation, the number of research areas to be considered was reduced to 11 areas.

Priority Setting Exercise: The members of the M&E TWG were asked to score each research area of interest against pre-defined criteria (*Appendix 2*), resulting in a prioritized list. The scores were weighted based on the pre-defined criteria: 10% Appropriateness, 30% Relevancy, 40% Chance of success, 20% Impact. The measure used to rank the areas was the likelihood that the research area satisfies the priority criteria. Using the following equation, each criterion was assessed based on responses from the prioritization exercise where the total possible score is $n \times 3$, where n is the number of respondents and the score achieved is the sum of the responses.

$$likelihood = \frac{Score\ achieved}{Total\ possible\ score} \times 100$$

Research areas scoring $\geq 80\%$ were considered high priority and the research areas scoring 70% - 79% were considered priority. There were 10 research areas that achieved above the threshold of 70% and 3 of these areas were deemed high priority as they scored above 80%.

Consensus Meeting: To form the final research agenda, the prioritized list was assessed by the M&E TWG to arrive at a consensus of the final ranked list of the research priorities.

RESEARCH PRIORITIES FOR THE NATIONAL HIV RESPONSE

Rank	Research Area	Total Score
1	HIV Prevention Measures	84%
	This area will explore the applicability of new and/or refined methods to the Jamaica population, specifically key populations, and youth. Topics in this area will include PrEP coverage and uptake, cultural acceptance, definition of minimum package of services and condom negotiation skills. Also this area will address research to investigate the best approaches for the prevention programme including recency assays use in surveillance.	
2	Ageing in PLHIV	80%
	Advances in treatment have improved life expectancy among PLHIV, however, challenges remain for those ageing with HIV. Included is the concept of premature ageing, changing health needs of ageing PLHIV and prevalence and incidence of non-AIDS related comorbidities. This research area will also investigate the morbidity and mortality associated with ageing in PLHIV to include readiness and absorptive capacity of the health care system to handle the changing demographic of the PLHIV population	
3	STI incidence, prevalence and epidemiology	80%
	Research in this area are wide ranging and address STI prevention, STI treatment and diagnosis, prevalence of STI and sexual behaviours	
4	Reproductive health in PLHIV	78%
	Research addressed in this are focused on the family planning services offered to PLHIV, the fertility intentions and messaging provided to PLHIV and the pre-conception health services offered. This area will also investigate factors related to mother to child transmission and vertical transmission	
5	Barriers/Facilitators to universal access to care for PLHIV	77%
	Universal access to care means that all people have access to the full range of quality health services needed, when and where they are needed and without financial hardship. Research in this area will investigate barriers and facilitators to access quality HIV care and achieving viral suppression for PLHIV. Integration of HIV treatment, care and support services into primary health care services is a key area that needs to be addressed.	

6	The impact of violence, trauma and adverse childhood events on health of PLHIV and key and vulnerable populations	74%
	Violence can affect the health of people who are targets, those who are perpetrators and the communities in which both live. Research questions within this area will investigate violence, trauma and adverse childhood events experienced by persons living with and affected by HIV. The impact of violence on physical, mental and behavioural health and the decision making among PLHIV will be explored. Also, investigations will focus on consent in sexual relations to include consent for PLHIV and age of consent	
7	Sustainability of the HIV/STI/TB programme	74%
	Sustainability of the HIV/STI/TB programme refers to the ability to maintain or support the programme continuously over time. Research in the area focus on the availability and distribution of resources for sustainability to include financial and human resources. A key component of this research area is a determination of the capacity of the health care system to maintain the HIV programme	
8	HIV drug resistance	73%
	Research in this area will cover the prevalence of the various drug resistance mutations, the prevalence of transmitted drug resistance and acquired drug resistance and the overall impact of drug resistance on treatment outcomes in PLHIV. Information in this area will inform the ARV regime selected for the population	
9	Co-infections and communicable diseases in PLHIV	72%
	Investigations are needed on the prevalence of endemic co-infections in the PLHIV population as well as the treatment outcomes in persons with co-infections. Also, research topics in this area surround the prevalence of opportunistic infections, mortality associated with opportunistic infection and treatment and care services for PLHIV with opportunistic infections	
10	Health information systems and data use for programme management	71%
	This area will explore the need for health information systems within the HIV programme. Investigations will examine the infrastructure in place/required for health information systems to provide information for programme management. Also, this area will explore the evaluation of health information systems on treatment outcomes of PLHIV	

STAKEHOLDER EXPECTATIONS AND RESPONSIBILITIES

Stakeholders within the national HIV response can support the successful implementation of this agenda by actively engaging with the established priorities and integrating them into their activities in the following way:

Ministry of Health and Wellness and Government Authorities

Expectations

- Lead the development and implementation of national policies related to HIV research.
- Provide funding and resources to support research initiatives.
- Ensure that research outcomes inform evidence-based policy making.
- Oversee the coordination of research activities within the country.

Responsibilities

- Allocate budgetary resources for HIV research.
- Establish and maintain ethical guidelines and regulatory frameworks for research.
- Collaborate with international organizations and donors to secure additional funding.
- Support the dissemination of research findings to the public and relevant stakeholders.

Researchers and Academia

Expectations

- Conduct rigorous and ethical research to address the research priorities of the HIV response.
- Generate high-quality data and evidence to inform decision-making.
- Collaborate with other researchers and institutions to share knowledge and resources.
- Publish research findings in peer-reviewed journals and present at conferences.

Responsibilities

- Develop research proposal and protocols aligned with the research agenda.
- Secure ethical approvals for research projects.
- Collect, analyse and interpret data accurately and transparently.
- Disseminate research findings in a timely manner, utilising channels outlined in the communication strategy.

Health Care Professionals and Service Providers

Expectations

- Utilise research findings to improve quality of HIV prevention, treatment and care services.
- Stay informed about the latest research development and best practices.
- Act as advocates for evidence-based healthcare approaches.

- Report data and outcomes from activities within the programme to contribute to research.

Responsibilities

- Incorporate research-based interventions into clinical practice.
- Participate in training and capacity building initiatives related to HIV research.
- Engage in data collection and reporting activities to support research efforts.
- Disseminate research findings within the health care community.

Civil Society Organisations and Advocacy Groups

Expectations

- Advocate for the rights and needs of people living with HIV.
- Promote community engagement in research activities.
- Contribute to raising awareness about the importance of research in the HIV response.
- Collaborate with researchers and policymakers to address gaps in services and policies.

Responsibilities

- Participate in research advisory committees and community engagement efforts.
- Advocate for increased funding for HIV research.
- Support the dissemination of research findings to affected communities.
- Hold policymakers accountable for implementing evidence-based policies.

People living with HIV (PLHIV)

Expectations

- Access and benefit from research-informed healthcare services and treatment and care.
- Have their voices heard in research planning and implementation.
- Receive information about research findings that directly impact their lives.
- Participate in research studies if willing and appropriate.

Responsibilities

- Engage in community-based research activities and advocacy.
- Provide input and feedback on research priorities and protocols.
- Share personal experiences and insights to inform research design.
- Advocate for equitable access to healthcare and support services based on research evidence.

International Donors and Organizations

Expectations

- Support research initiatives through funding and technical assistance.
- Collaborate with the government and local organizations to strengthen research capacity.

- Ensure research outcomes are aligned with global HIV goals.
- Monitor the progress and impact of research investments.

Responsibilities

- Provide financial and technical support for research projects.
- Foster collaboration and knowledge sharing among countries and regions.
- Advocate for evidence-based policies and practices.
- Share lessons learned and best practices from other countries and regions with Jamaica's research community.

Guidelines for the Communication and Dissemination of the Research Agenda

This guideline outlines the strategies and mechanisms for the communication and dissemination of the research agenda, research finding and other key information to stakeholders.

Objectives

1. **Raise Awareness.** To increase public and stakeholder awareness of the research priorities and of the importance of research in shaping the HIV response.
2. **Knowledge Sharing.** To facilitate the sharing of research findings, insights and best practices among researchers, policy makers and implementers.
3. **Evidence-Based Decision Making.** To promote the use of research outcomes in policymaking and programme development.

Target Audiences

- Ministry of Health and Wellness officials and policy makers
- Other line ministries including Ministry of Labour and Social Security, Ministry of National Security, Ministry of Education and Youth
- Other government agencies including the Planning Institute of Jamaica (PIOJ)
- Healthcare professionals and service providers both private and public
- Researchers and Academia
- Civil Society Organizations
- People Living with HIV
- Health and Life Insurance Companies
- General Public

Communication Strategies and Dissemination Channels

1. **Research Agenda Launch.** Host the key stakeholders and organize a launch of the research agenda at the start of the agenda period.
2. **Research Symposium.** Organize a biennial national symposium to showcase the research finding and promote dialogue among stakeholders.
3. **Webinars and Workshops.** Host webinars and workshops to engage stakeholders and share research updates.

4. **Publications.** Develop research briefs, policy papers and peer-reviewed articles for dissemination through academic journals and government publications.
5. **Media Engagement.** Collaborate with media outlets for feature articles, interviews, and documentaries to raise awareness and disseminate key messages.
6. **Website.** Maintain a dedicated website for the Research Agenda with regularly updated content including research reports and resources including conference opportunities.
7. **Social Media.** Utilize social media platforms to share research highlights, infographics and engage with the online community.
8. **Email Updates.** Send regular email updates to a subscribed list of stakeholders.
9. **Print Materials.** Produce printed materials for distribution at conferences, workshops, and community events.

Evaluation

Regularly assess the effectiveness of the communication and dissemination activities through feedback mechanisms, surveys and key performance indicators associated with specific channels.

Key Milestones

- At the start of the Research Agenda period activities should be geared towards promoting awareness among all stakeholders. A formal launch of the research agenda will mark the beginning of the research agenda period. Additionally, a high level meeting ensures that the research agenda is seen as a priority among the decision makers.
- A mid-point evaluation of the research priorities must be conducted by the Research Agenda Technical Working Group within 2 – 3 years of the start of the research agenda. Communication activities at this time must disseminate the finding of the evaluation.
- At the end of the Research Agenda period dissemination activities should culminate in a symposium highlighting research findings, programmatic changes and policies developed based on information from the research activities and the method and process in developing and reviewing the research agenda.

A detailed timeline outlining these key milestones and deadlines for the communication activities will be needed.

APPENDIX

Appendix 1: Members of the Research Agenda Technical Working Group

1. Jamaica Council of Churches (JCC)
2. CTECH
3. Pan American Health Organization (PAHO)
4. UNAIDS
5. National Family Planning Board (NFPB)
6. University of California, San Francisco (UCSF)
7. Jamaica AIDS Support for Life (JASL)
8. Jamaicans for Justice (JFJ)
9. Ministry of Labour and Social Security (MLSS)
10. TPDCO
11. Centres for Disease Prevention and Control (CDC)
12. Transwave
13. Equality for All
14. Jamaica Network of Seropositives (JN+)
15. Western Regional Health Authority (WRHA)
16. Northeast Regional Health Authority (NERHA)
17. Southern Regional Health Authority (SRHA)
18. Southeast Regional Health Authority (SERHA)
19. Ministry of Health and Wellness (MOHW)

Appendix 2: Criteria for priority setting

Total Possible Score = 24

Appropriateness (Total 6) – Is the proposed research well suited to the target population? Does the proposed research duplicate past studies?

Is the planned research ethically and morally acceptable?

- 3 No foreseeable problem
- 2 Sensitive Issue
- 1 Debatable, equivocal
- 0 Unacceptable (topic should be deemed inappropriate)

How adequate and valid is any available research-based information on this topic?

- 3 Non in Existence
- 2 Scarce Inadequate
- 1 Abundant and Not Valid
- 0 Abundant and Valid

Relevancy (Total 6) – Is the proposed research the right kind, for the right people and is pertinent to the health problems of the community without disregarding equity issues?

How much does the research topic serve the community concern or demand?

- 3 High
- 2 Moderate
- 1 Low or none
- 0 Don't Know

How much does the research in this area contribute to greater equity in health in terms of socio-demographic, economic, health service access/delivery and gender?

- 3 High
- 2 Moderate
- 1 Low or none
- 0 Don't Know

The chance of success (Total 6) – What are the strengths and resources of the research team?

How adequate is the capacity of the system to undertake the research in terms of competency, infrastructure, support system, mechanisms and resources?

3 Excellent

2 Good

1 Poor

0 Don't Know

How justifiable is the cost for this research project?

3 Very Appropriate

2 Acceptable

1 Unclear, Uncertain

Impact of the research outcome (Total 6) – What are the benefits of using or implementing the research results? What is the merit or usefulness of the research outcome?

What are the chances of the recommendation being implemented and the project being sustained?

3 High

2 Fair or Moderate

1 Low or none

0 Don't Know

How much impact will this research have on the health of the population? (Average)

3 High

2 Fair or Moderate

1 Low or none

0 Don't Know